

OpenClaw API-KEY Configuration

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1. Course Content
2. Applying for an API-KEY
 - 2.1 Recommended Model Service Providers
3. Configuring the OpenClaw API-KEY
 - 3.1 Configuration Methods
 - 3.2 Quick Configuration
 - 3.2.1 Configuring the Base URL
 - 3.2.2 Filling in the apiKey
4. Viewing Connected Model Status
 - 4.1 View the List of Configured Models
 - 4.2 Verify Whether the Configuration Was Successful
5. Other Ways to Connect
 - 5.1 CLI Command Configuration (Suitable for Beginners)
 - 5.2 Modifying the Configuration File (Recommended Method)
 - Configuration File Location
 - Editing the Configuration File
6. Common Problems and Solutions

1. Course Content

This course details how to configure the API-KEY for AI models in OpenClaw, including the API-KEY application process, two configuration methods (CLI command configuration and configuration file modification), and how to verify whether the configuration was successful. After completing this course, you will be able to successfully connect to and use various AI large model service providers.

Course Objectives

- Understand the types of model service providers supported by OpenClaw
- Master the method for applying for an API-KEY
- Learn to view and verify the status of connected models

2. Applying for an API-KEY

2.1 Recommended Model Service Providers

- For the API-KEY application, refer to the companion tutorial [AI Large Model Development] — [Register Model Service Account]
- OpenClaw supports many model service providers, for example:
 - **OpenAI**
 - **Alibaba Cloud** - Qwen (Tongyi Qianwen)
 - **DeepSeek**
 - **Zhipu AI**
 - **Moonshot AI**
- You can freely choose a model service provider according to the network policies of your country/region, and register on the corresponding official website to apply for an API-KEY

3. Configuring the OpenClaw API-KEY

3.1 Configuration Methods

OpenClaw provides two ways to configure the API-KEY:

1. **CLI command configuration** (suitable for beginners)
2. **Directly modifying the configuration file** (suitable for developers)
3. Configuration file path: `$HOME/.openclaw/openclaw.json`

3.2 Quick Configuration

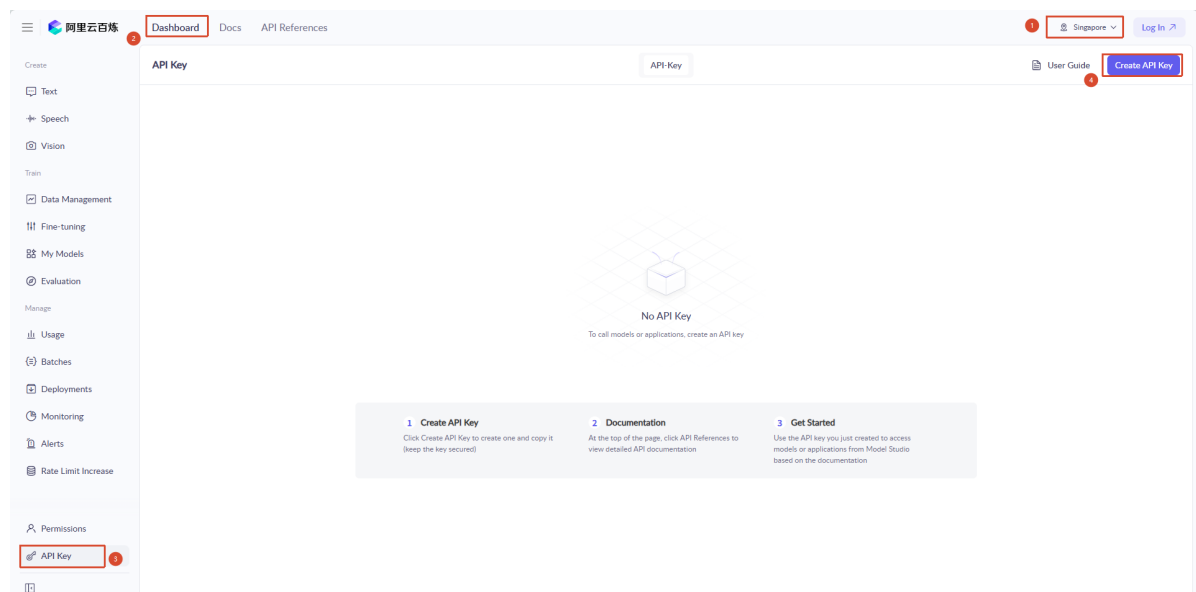
[!NOTE]

- The factory-default **openclaw.json** configuration file comes with the baseurl and commonly used models of the Alibaba Cloud Bailian platform built in, for quick configuration and use.
- Suitable for a quick first-time experience: first register an Alibaba Cloud Bailian large model account and create an API-KEY (refer to the companion tutorial [AI Large Model Development] — [Register Model Service Account])
- The factory-default configuration file already has the Bailian model parameters configured; just fill in the API-KEY and you can use it directly
- Open the OpenClaw configuration file:

```
nano $HOME/.openclaw/openclaw.json
```

3.2.1 Configuring the Base URL

- Users overseas: choose the corresponding baseurl according to the service region you use (go to the [Alibaba Cloud Bailian Console](#) homepage, switch to the target region in the upper-right corner of the page, such as **Singapore**, then select **API Key** in the left navigation bar to enter the management page and create an API Key)



Save Your API Key

 You cannot get this key again after you close this dialog box.

Immediately copy or download your API key.Keep this key secure. Anyone with access can make requests on your behalf and incur charges. If the key is lost, reset it or create a new one

API Key

sk-w [redacted]

✓ Copy

API Host

v[redacted].s.com

OpenAI Compatible Endpoint

https://[redacted]n/compatible-mode/v1

DashScope

https://w[redacted]n/api/v1

Hide ^

Description

-

Workspace

Download

Close

3.2.2 Filling in the apiKey

- Find the corresponding field and replace the baseurl and apiKey fields

```
"models": {  
  "mode": "merge",  
  "providers": {  
    "bailian": {  
      "baseUrl": "https://dashscope.aliyuncs.com/compatible-mode/v1",  
      "apiKey": "sk-a87e1137b17b4a35af13aa4a12ac3473",  
    }  
  }  
}
```

- After filling in, press `Ctrl+X`, then press `Y` to confirm saving, and finally press `Enter` to exit

4. Viewing Connected Model Status

4.1 View the List of Configured Models

After the configuration is complete, you can use the following command to view the connected models:

```
openclaw models list
```

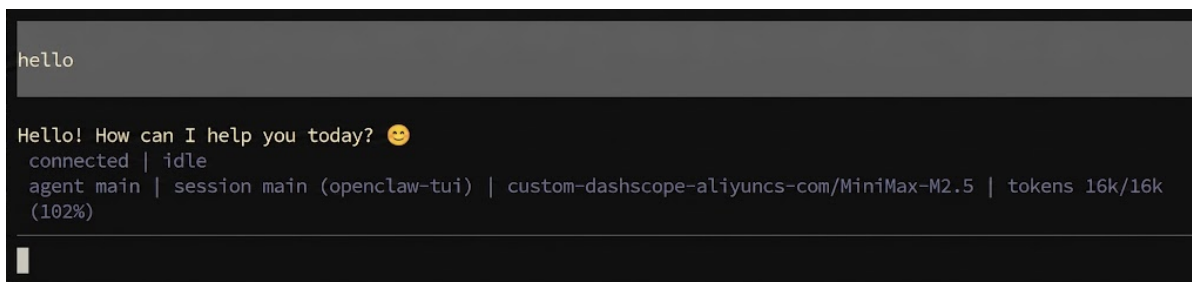
Model	Input	Ctx	Local	Auth	Tags
custom-dashscope-aliyuncs-com/MiniMax-M2.5	text	16k	no	yes	default, configured
bailian/qwen3.5-plus	text+image	977k	no	yes	configured
bailian/qwen3.6-plus	text+image	977k	no	yes	configured
bailian/qwen3-max-2026-01-23	text	977k	no	yes	configured
bailian/qwen3-coder-next	text	256k	no	yes	configured
bailian/qwen3-coder-plus	text	977k	no	yes	configured
bailian/MiniMax-M2.5	text	192k	no	yes	configured
bailian/glm-5	text	198k	no	yes	configured
bailian/glm-4.7	text	198k	no	yes	configured
bailian/kimi-k2.5	text+image	256k	no	yes	configured

4.2 Verify Whether the Configuration Was Successful

1. Test conversation

```
openclaw tui
```

Launch the TUI interface, send a test message (such as "Hello"), and confirm that the model responds normally.



5. Other Ways to Connect

- If you have your own model provider or need to connect other model providers later, refer to the following tutorials

5.1 CLI Command Configuration (Suitable for Beginners)

1. Start the configuration wizard

```
openclaw onboard
```

- Select **【Yes】** and press Enter

```
Recommended baseline:
- Pairing/allowlists + mention gating.
- Multi-user/shared inbox: split trust boundaries (separate
  gateway/credentials, ideally separate OS users/hosts).
- Sandbox + least-privilege tools.
- Shared inboxes: isolate DM sessions (`session.dmScope:
  per-channel-peer`) and keep tool access minimal.
- Keep secrets out of the agent's reachable filesystem.
- Use the strongest available model for any bot with tools or
  untrusted inboxes.
```

```
Run regularly:
openclaw security audit --deep
openclaw security audit --fix
```

```
Must read: https://docs.openclaw.ai/gateway/security
```

```
◆ I understand this is personal-by-default and shared/multi-user use requires
lock-down. Continue?
  ● Yes / ○ No
```

- Select QuickStart as the configuration mode and press Enter

```
◆ Setup mode
  ● QuickStart (Configure details later via openclaw configure.)
  ○ Manual
```

2. Select the model service provider

- Use the up/down arrow keys to select the provider for which you have applied for an API-KEY, and press Enter to confirm. Here, the Alibaba Cloud Bailian model provider is used as an example; the configuration process is the same for other model providers.
- Here, select the custom provider **【Custom Provider】**

```
◆ Model/auth provider

Search:
  ○ Alibaba Model Studio
  ○ Anthropic
  ○ Arcee AI
  ○ BytePlus
  ○ Chutes
  ○ Cloudflare AI Gateway
  ○ Copilot
  ● Custom Provider (Any OpenAI or Anthropic compatible endpoint)
```

- Fill in the model provider's base_url

```
◆ API Base URL
  https://dashscope.aliyuncs.com/compatible-mode/v1
```

3. Enter the API-KEY

- After selecting the provider, the system will prompt you to enter the corresponding API-KEY

```
◆ How do you want to provide this API key?  
● Paste API key now (Stores the key directly in OpenClaw config)  
○ Use external secret provider
```

- Paste or enter the API-KEY you applied for, then press Enter to confirm

```
◆ API Key (leave blank if not required)  
sk-a87e1137b17b4a35af13aa4a1xxxxxx
```

- Select **OpenAI-compatible** as the API protocol

```
◆ Endpoint compatibility  
● OpenAI-compatible (Uses /chat/completions)  
○ Anthropic-compatible  
○ Unknown (detect automatically)
```

4. Fill in the model name; here, MiniMax is used as an example

```
◆ Model ID  
MiniMax-M2.5
```

- **Endpoint ID** is an identifier for the model provider and can be filled in freely

```
◆ Endpoint ID  
custom-dashscope-aliyuncs-com
```

- Leave Model alias (optional) blank directly

```
◆ Model alias (optional)  
e.g. local, ollama
```

5. Other configurations

- Select skip for all other configuration items as shown in the figures below; they do not need to be configured

```
◇ Skills status

Eligible: 16
Missing requirements: 38
Unsupported on this OS: 7
Blocked by allowlist: 0

◆ Configure skills now? (recommended)
  ○ Yes / ● No
```

- For Enable Hooks, press Space to select **Skip for now**

```
Enable hooks?
■ Skip for now
□ 🚀 boot-md
□ 📎 bootstrap-extra-files
□ 📝 command-logger
□ 💾 session-memory
```

- Select Restart to restart the gateway and apply the configuration

```
Gateway service already installed
● Restart
○ Reinstall
○ Skip
```

5.2 Modifying the Configuration File (Recommended Method)

Configuration File Location

- The configuration file is located at: `$HOME/.openclaw/openclaw.json`

Editing the Configuration File

```
nano $HOME/.openclaw/openclaw.json
# Or use your preferred editor, such as vim, code, etc. It is recommended to edit
with an IDE like VS Code for more convenience
```

1. Add the model provider configuration

Add or modify the `models.providers` section in the configuration file. Refer to the format below; you can also refer to the configuration format of the factory-default **bailian** provider:

```
{
  "models": {
    "providers": {
      "openai": {
        "apiKey": "OPENAI_API_KEY"
      },
      "anthropic": {
        "apiKey": "ANTHROPIC_API_KEY"
      },
      "google": {
        "apiKey": "GOOGLE_API_KEY"
      }
    }
  },
  "agents": {
    "defaults": {
      "model": {
        "primary": "openai/gpt-4"
      }
    }
  }
}
```

```
},
"models": {
  "mode": "merge",
  "providers": {
    "bailian": {
      "baseUrl": "https://dashscope.aliyuncs.com/compatible-mode/v1",
      "apiKey": "sk-f4b28ceb5fd54f14ad9311xxxxxxxxxxxxxxxx",
      "api": "openai-completions",
      "models": [
        {
          "id": "qwen3.5-plus",
          "name": "qwen3.5-plus",
          "api": "openai-completions",
          "reasoning": false,
          "input": [
            "text",
            "image"
          ],
          "cost": {
            "input": 0,
            "output": 0,
            "cacheRead": 0,
            "cacheWrite": 0
          },
          "contextWindow": 1000000,
          "maxTokens": 65536
        }
      ]
    }
  }
}
```

3. Save and exit

- o Press `Ctrl+O` to save and `Ctrl+X` to exit (nano editor)

4. Factory-default Bailian configuration (you can modify it directly or use it as a reference)

```
"bailian": {
  "baseUrl": "https://dashscope.aliyuncs.com/compatible-mode/v1",
  "apiKey": "sk-a87e1137b17b4a35af13aaxxxxxxx",
  "api": "openai-completions",
  "models": [
    {
      "id": "qwen3.5-plus",
      "name": "qwen3.5-plus",
      "api": "openai-completions",
      "reasoning": false,
      "input": [
        "text",
        "image"
      ],
      "cost": {
        "input": 0,
        "output": 0,
        "cacheRead": 0,
        "cacheWrite": 0
      },
      "contextWindow": 1000000,
      "maxTokens": 65536
    },
    {
      "id": "qwen3.6-plus",
      "name": "qwen3.6-plus",
      "api": "openai-completions",
      "reasoning": false,
      "input": [
        "text",
        "image"
      ],
      "cost": {
        "input": 0,
        "output": 0,
        "cacheRead": 0,
        "cacheWrite": 0
      },
      "contextWindow": 1000000,
      "maxTokens": 65536
    },
    {
      "id": "qwen3-coder-next",
      "name": "qwen3-coder-next",
      "api": "openai-completions",
      "reasoning": false,
      "input": [
        "text"
      ],
      "cost": {
        "input": 0,
        "output": 0,
        "cacheRead": 0,
```

```
        "cachewrite": 0
    },
    "contextwindow": 262144,
    "maxTokens": 65536
},
{
    "id": "MiniMax-M2.5",
    "name": "MiniMax-M2.5",
    "api": "openai-completions",
    "reasoning": false,
    "input": [
        "text"
    ],
    "cost": {
        "input": 0,
        "output": 0,
        "cacheRead": 0,
        "cachewrite": 0
    },
    "contextwindow": 196608,
    "maxTokens": 32768
},
{
    "id": "glm-5",
    "name": "glm-5",
    "api": "openai-completions",
    "reasoning": false,
    "input": [
        "text"
    ],
    "cost": {
        "input": 0,
        "output": 0,
        "cacheRead": 0,
        "cachewrite": 0
    },
    "contextwindow": 202752,
    "maxTokens": 16384,
    "compat": {
        "thinkingFormat": "qwen"
    }
},
{
    "id": "glm-4.7",
    "name": "glm-4.7",
    "api": "openai-completions",
    "reasoning": false,
    "input": [
        "text"
    ],
    "cost": {
        "input": 0,
        "output": 0,
        "cacheRead": 0,
        "cachewrite": 0
    },
    "contextwindow": 202752,
    "maxTokens": 16384,
```

```

        "compat": {
            "thinkingFormat": "qwen"
        }
    },
    {
        "id": "kimi-k2.5",
        "name": "kimi-k2.5",
        "api": "openai-completions",
        "reasoning": false,
        "input": [
            "text",
            "image"
        ],
        "cost": {
            "input": 0,
            "output": 0,
            "cacheRead": 0,
            "cacheWrite": 0
        },
        "contextWindow": 262144,
        "maxTokens": 32768,
        "compat": {
            "thinkingFormat": "qwen"
        }
    }
]
}

```

6. Common Problems and Solutions

Problem: After configuration, a prompt indicates that the API-KEY is invalid or authentication failed

1. Confirm that the API-KEY is correct (be careful not to have extra spaces)
2. Check whether the API-KEY has expired or been disabled
3. Confirm that the account balance is sufficient (some providers require prepayment)

Problem: The configuration is correct but the model service cannot be connected

1. Check whether the network connection is normal
2. Confirm whether the network in your country/region can access the service
3. Try switching to another model service provider for testing